

Economic History II

School, language and national identity

FGV EPGE

Outline of the class

- What is a nation? **Imagined communities**.
- The school as the instrument:
 - The making of France (Blanc and Kubo).
- **Backlash:**
 - German banned in US schools (Fouka).
 - The headscarf ban in France.

Imagined communities

Benedict Anderson

What is a nation?

- Anderson (1983): the nation as an **imagined** political community.
- Imagined: members will never meet most of their fellow members.
- Limited: finite borders, other nations beyond them. Sovereign: no dynastic realm above it.
- Preconditions he stresses: mass literacy in the vernacular, print capitalism, the end of rule by divine right.
- Nations are recent. They had to be built, and someone had to build them.

BENEDICT
ANDERSON



IMAGINED
COMMUNITIES

*Reflections on the Origin and
Spread of Nationalism*

Imagined community

 21 languages 

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From Wikipedia, the free encyclopedia

"Imagined communities" redirects here. For the book, see [Imagined Communities](#).

An **imagined community** is a concept developed by [Benedict Anderson](#) in his 1983 book *[Imagined Communities](#)* to analyze [nationalism](#). Anderson depicts a [nation](#) as a socially-constructed community, imagined by the people who perceive themselves as part of a group.^[1]:6–7

Anderson focuses on the way [media](#) creates imagined communities, especially the power of print media in shaping an individual's social psyche. Anderson analyzes the written word, a tool used by churches, authors, and media companies (notably books, newspapers, and magazines), as well as governmental tools such as the map, the census, and the museum. These tools were all built to target and define a mass audience in the public sphere through dominant images, ideologies, and language. Anderson explores the racist and colonial origins of these practices before explaining a general theory that explains how contemporary governments and corporations can (and frequently do) utilize these same practices. These theories were not originally applied to the Internet or television.

Origin  [edit](#)

Historical argument [\[edit \]](#)

According to Anderson's theory of imagined communities, the main historical causes of nationalism include:

- the increasing importance of mass [vernacular](#) literacy,
- the movement to abolish the ideas of rule by divine right and hereditary monarchy ("the concept was born in an age in which Enlightenment and Revolution were destroying the legitimacy of the divinely ordained, hierarchical dynastic realm....[N]ations dream of being free...The gage and emblem of this freedom is the sovereign state...", 1991, 7);
- and the emergence of [Print capitalism](#) ("the convergence of capitalism and print technology... standardization of national calendars, clocks and language was embodied in books and the publication of daily newspapers")^[2]

All of these phenomena coincided with the start of the [Industrial Revolution](#).^{[2][4]}

Nation as an imagined community [\[edit \]](#)

According to Anderson, [nations](#) are [socially constructed](#).^[5] For Anderson, the idea of the "nation" is relatively new and is a product of various socio-material forces. He defined a nation as "an imagined political community – and imagined as both inherently limited and sovereign".^[6] As Anderson puts it, a nation "is imagine

Nation as an imagined community [\[edit \]](#)

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Nations are "limited" in that they have "finite, if elastic boundaries, beyond which lie other nations".^[6] They are "sovereign" since no dynastic monarchy can claim authority over them, in the modern period:

[T]he concept was born in an age in which Enlightenment and Revolution were destroying the legitimacy of the divinely-ordained, hierarchical dynastic realm. Coming to maturity at a stage of human history when even the most devout adherents of any universal religion were inescapably confronted with the living pluralism of such religions, and the allomorphy [incongruence, divide] between each faith's ontological claims and territorial stretch, nations dream of being free, and, if under God, directly so. The gauge and emblem of this freedom is the sovereign state.^[6]

Even though we may never see anyone in our imagined community, we still know they are there through communication means such as newspapers. He describes the act of reading a daily paper as a "mass ceremony":

"It is performed in silent privacy, in the lair of the skull. Yet each communicant is well aware that the ceremony he performs is being replicated simultaneously by thousands (or millions) of others of whose existence he is confident, yet of whose identity he has not the slightest notion." (35)

Finally, a nation is a [community](#) because,

regardless of the actual inequality and exploitation that may prevail in each, the nation is always conceived as a deep, horizontal comradeship. Ultimately it is this fraternity that makes it possible, over the past two centuries, for so many millions of people, not so much to kill, as willingly to die for such limited imaginings.^[6]

Nation building

Making citizens

- Nineteenth century: policies of **homogenization** and assimilation advanced social cohesion and political stability, at the expense of diversity.
- Napoleon, 1805: “There cannot be a firmly established political state unless there is a teaching body with definitely recognized principles. If the child is not taught from infancy that he ought to be a republican or a monarchist, a Catholic or a free-thinker, the state will not constitute a nation; it will rest on uncertain and shifting foundations; and it will be constantly exposed to disorder and change.”
- After Italian unification, d’Azeglio: Italy has been made, Italians still have to be.
- Alesina, Giuliano and Reich: the threat of democratization or civil conflict is the strongest determinant of homogenization.

Nation-Building and Education



Alberto Alesina, Paola Giuliano & Bryony Reich

Nations stay together when citizens share enough values and preferences and can communicate with each other. Democracies and dictatorships have different incentives when it comes to choosing how much and by what means to homogenize the population, i.e. "to build a nation". We study and compare nation-building policies under the transition from dictatorship to democracy in a model where the location and type of government and the borders of the country are endogenous. We find that the threat of democratization provides the strongest incentive to homogenize. We focus upon a specific nation-building policy: the provision of mass primary education. As a motivation, we offer historical discussions of several episodes in the nineteenth century and suggestive correlations for a large sample of countries over the 1925-2014 period.

“There cannot be a firmly established political state unless there is a teaching body with definitely recognized principles. If the child is not taught from infancy that he ought to be a republican or a monarchist, a Catholic or a free-thinker, the state will not constitute a nation; it will rest on uncertain and shifting foundations; and it will be constantly exposed to disorder and change.” Napoleon I, 1805¹

In 1860 French was still a foreign language to half of all French children.² Outside major cities, France was a country of different languages, dialects and diverse currencies.³ Travel far outside one’s own village was rare, and indifference or hostility to the French state common.⁴ From the French Revolution and throughout the 19th century, French rulers expressed the imperative “to form French citizens”.⁵ Following the unification of Italy (1860), a process led by a Northern elite which then ruled the country, Massimo d’Azeglio (one of the founders of unified Italy) famously remarked: “Italy has been made; now it remains to make Italians.” In

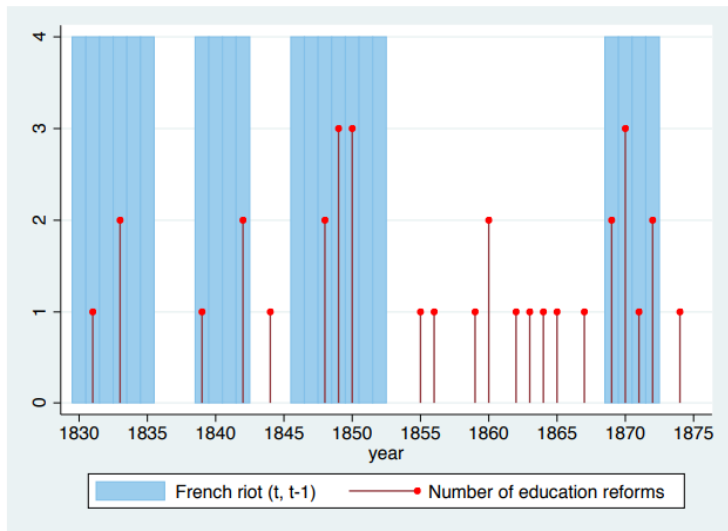


Figure 2: Years of major rioting in France and number of education reforms across Europe

Curriculum as nation building, still

- Argentina: the **Malvinas** taught as a school subject, with an official teaching kit, classroom posters, and a march learned by heart.
- United States: the Pledge of Allegiance recited in school.
- Brazil: schools required to sing the national anthem, and a calendar of civic dates.
- In every case the content is chosen centrally and the school is where it is delivered.



2 de abril

Malvinas en la escuela

Presentamos una selección de producciones elaboradas por el Programa Educación y Memoria para abordar la enseñanza de Malvinas. Este material —que invita a reflexionar en el marco de la memoria, la soberanía y la democracia— constituye un aporte para el trabajo de docentes y estudiantes de las escuelas de todo el país.

Más recursos

Publicaciones

Especiales sobre Malvinas

Entrevistas

Programas Canal Encuentro

Literatura y Malvinas



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Marcha de las Malvinas

Tras su manto de neblinas,
no las hemos de olvidar,
"Las Malvinas Argentinas",
clama el viento y ruga el mar.

Ni de aquellos horizontes
nuestra enseña han de arrancar,
pues su blanco está en los montes
y en su azul se tiñe el mar.

Por ausente, por vencido
bajo extraño pabellón,
ningún suelo más querido,
de la patria en la extensión.

¿Quién nos habla aquí de olvido,
de renuncia o de perdón?
Ningún suelo más querido,
de la patria en la extensión.

Rompa el manto de neblinas,
como un sol, nuestro ideal:
"Las Malvinas Argentinas
en dominio ya inmortal".

Y ante el sol de nuestro emblema,
pura, nítida y triunfal,
brille, oh, Patria, en tu diadema,
la perdida perla austral.

¡Para honor de nuestro emblema
para orgullo nacional,
brille, oh, Patria, en tu diadema,
la perdida perla austral.

Para honor de nuestro emblema
para orgullo nacional
Brille, oh, Patria, en tu diadema,
la perdida perla austral.



Recital [[edit](#)]

[Congressional](#) sessions open with the recital of the Pledge, as do many government meetings at local levels, and meetings held by many private organizations. All states except [Nebraska](#), [Hawaii](#), [Vermont](#), and [Wyoming](#) require a regularly scheduled recitation of the pledge in [public schools](#).^[13] Many states give a variety of exemptions from reciting the pledge, such as California which requires a "patriotic exercise" every day, which would be satisfied by the Pledge, but it is not enforced.^[14] The [Supreme Court](#) has ruled in *[West Virginia State Board of Education v. Barnette](#)* that students cannot be compelled to recite the Pledge, nor can they be punished for not doing so.^[15] In several states, [state flag](#) pledges of allegiance are required to be recited after the pledge to the American flag.^[16]

The current [United States Flag Code](#) says:

The Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag: "I pledge allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America, and to the Republic for which it stands, one Nation under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all," should be rendered by standing at attention facing the flag with the right hand over the heart. When not in uniform, men should remove any non-religious headdress with their right hand and hold it at the left shoulder, the hand being over the heart. Persons in uniform should remain silent, face the flag, and render the military salute.^[17] Members of the Armed Forces not in uniform and veterans may render the military salute in the manner provided for persons in uniform.^[4]

Origins [[edit](#)]

Historians point to surges in American patriotic oaths and pledges to the flag after the Civil

1954 (current version, per 4 U.S.C. §4)^[4]

"I pledge allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America, and to the Republic for which it stands, one nation under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all."



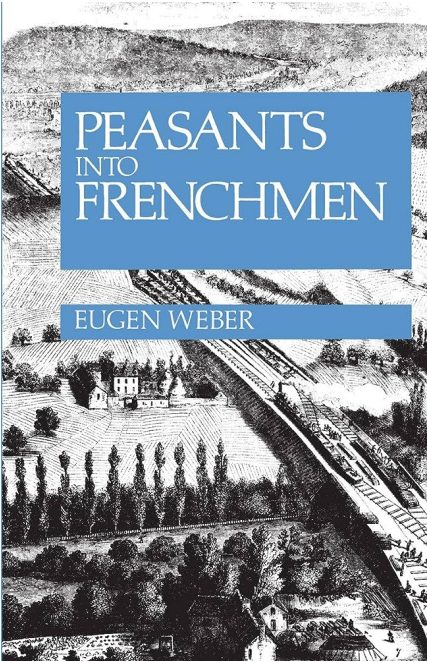
[School](#)children in 1899 reciting the Pledge of Allegiance ↗



Students recite the Pledge of Allegiance at [Hayesville High School](#) in 2004 ↗

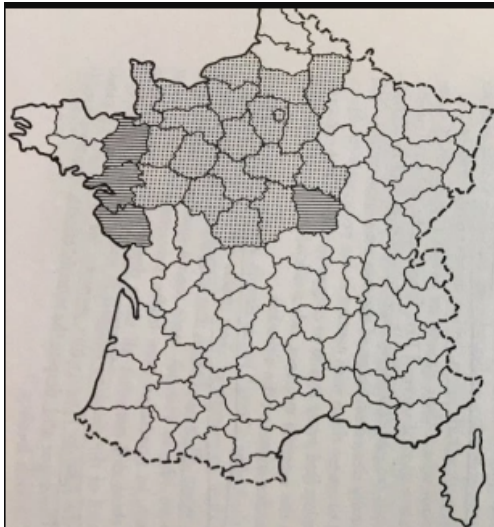
Peasants into Frenchmen

- Eugen **Weber** (1976): France became a nation late, through schools, roads, railways and conscription.
- “The Third Republic found a France in which French was a foreign language for half the citizens” (Weber, 1976, p. 70).
- Blanc and Kubo move the turning point earlier: to the Guizot Law of 1833, not the Ferry Laws of 1881 and 1882.

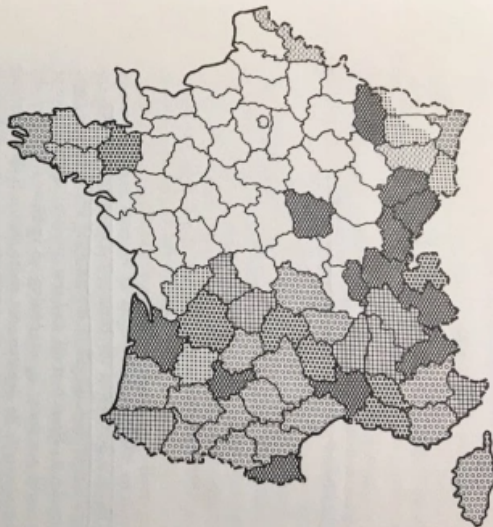


PEASANTS INTO FRENCHMEN

EUGEN WEBER



-  wholly French-speaking
-  largely French-speaking but with some cantons holding to their own dialects



-  all or nearly all communes non-French-speaking
-  50% + of communes non-French-speaking
-  significant proportion of communes non-French-speaking
-  cohesive groups of communes non-French-speaking
-  patois indicated
-  questionable

The making of France

Blanc and Kubo

The Making of France

Guillaume Blanc and Masahiro Kubo*

February 11, 2026

[Link to the latest version](#)

Abstract

This paper studies nation-building in a fragmented society. We document the political economy of mass education, the adoption of a common language, and the construction of a national identity in France. Using a regression discontinuity design, we show that state-sponsored education led to linguistic homogenization. To understand why nation-building was successful, we study heterogeneity and find that knowledge elites and the demand for education were instrumental.

JEL codes: P00, H52, I25, N33, Z13, D72

Keywords: nation-building, language, mass education, institutions

France before French

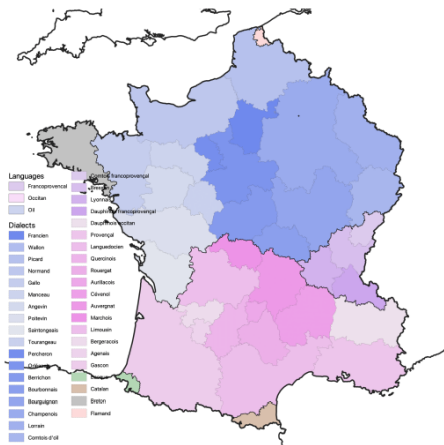
- More than forty languages and dialects spoken historically: the **langues d'oïl** in the north, the *lenga d'òc* (Occitan) in the south, plus Breton, Basque, Alsatian, Catalan, Flemish.
- Occitan was largely unintelligible to speakers of the langues d'oïl, and closest to Catalan.
- It was the language of the troubadours. Dante counted *oc* as one of three families of vernacular Romance.
- Grégoire (1794): “we are still, for language, the Tower of Babel”. He counted three million fluent speakers of French out of twenty-nine million inhabitants.

Three centuries of decrees, little effect

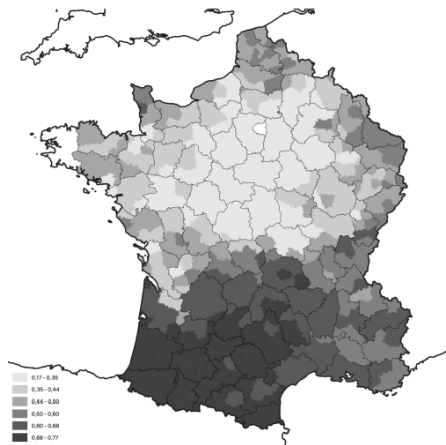
- **Villers-Cotterêts**, 1539: French required in legal documents, parish records, contracts. Other tongues relegated to spoken use.
- Its real target was Latin, not the dialects. Local speech was virtually unaffected.
- Revolutionary projects for universal schooling (Talleyrand, Condorcet): none carried to its term.
- Today French is the only recognized official language and most of the other tongues are endangered.

Figure 3: Historical language regions and linguistic distance from French in 1900

Note: This figure displays the spatial distribution of historical languages and dialects (Panel A) and linguistic distance from French in 1900 (Panel B). Linguistic distance from French is defined as the Levenshtein distance from Le Plessis-Robinson. Observations are at the municipality level, but, to ease readability, we generate Thiessen polygons around each town surveyed in the *Atlas* to plot our measure. Sources: Billy, Nadiras and Moufflet (n.d.) for historical language regions, Gilliéron and Edmont (1902-1910) and authors' calculations for linguistic distance from French.



(Panel A) Historical language regions



(Panel B) Linguistic distance from French (1900)

Reading the map

- Left: historical language regions. Right: how far each village's speech sat from French in 1900.
- Darker means **farther** from French: the whole Occitan south, and the peripheries generally.
- The 1900 measure still traces the old regions, so it picks up deep-rooted differences as well as recent change.

Figure 1: Mirèio (1859), Frédéric Mistral

Note: This figure displays the first page of the poem "Mirèio" in Provençal (Panel A) and in French (Panel B). Source: gallica.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/bpt6k7490v.

MIRÈIO

CANT PROUMIÈ

LOU MAS DI FALABREGO.

Cante uno chato de Prouvènço.
Dins lis amour de sa jouvènço,
A travès de la Crau, vers la mar, dins li bla,
Umble escoulan dóu grand Oumèro,
Iéu la vole seguí. Coume èro
Rèn qu'uno chato de la terro,
En foro de la Crau se n'es gaire parla.

Emai soun front noun lusiguèsse
Que de jouinesso; emai n'aguèsse
Ni diadèmo d'or ni mantèu de Damas,
Vole qu'en glòri fugue aussado
Coume uno rèino, e caressado
Pèr nosto lengo mespresado,
Car cantan que pèr vautre, o pastre e gènt di mas!

(Panel A) Provençal



CHANT PREMIER

LE MAS DES MICOCOULES. (1)

Je chante une jeune fille de Provence. — Dans
les amours de sa jeunesse, — à travers la Crau (2),
vers la mer, dans les blés, — humble écolier du
grand Homère, — je veux la suivre. Comme c'é-
tait — seulement une fille de la glèbe, — en
dehors de la Crau il s'en est peu parlé.

Bien que son front ne brillât — que de jeunes-
se; bien qu'elle n'eût — ni diadème d'or ni man-
teau de Damas, — je veux qu'en gloire elle soit
élevée — comme une reine, et caressée — par
notre langue méprisée, — car nous ne chantons
que pour vous, ô pâtres et habitants des mas.

(Panel B) French

Figure A4: Street names

Note: This figure displays street names in Alsacien (Panel A) and Provençal (Panel B) dialects. Sources: Wikipedia.



(Panel A) Alsacien



(Panel B) Provençal

The question

- How does a state turn a fragmented society into a nation with a common language and a common identity?
- Blanc and Kubo study the **public school** as the instrument: instruction in and of French, national history, state-approved textbooks, state-trained teachers.
- And they ask why the policy took hold in some places and not in others.

Two laws of the July Monarchy

- **Municipal Law of 1831**: local elections for the first time. Above 500 inhabitants, relatives were barred from sitting together on the council, and the council grew from 10 to 12 members.
- **Guizot Law of 1833**: every municipality to have a primary school for boys, a state-designed curriculum, state textbooks, teachers trained in new departmental normal schools, inspectors and committees to enforce it.
- The Guizot Law was funded and implemented by the municipal councils. Local willingness decided.

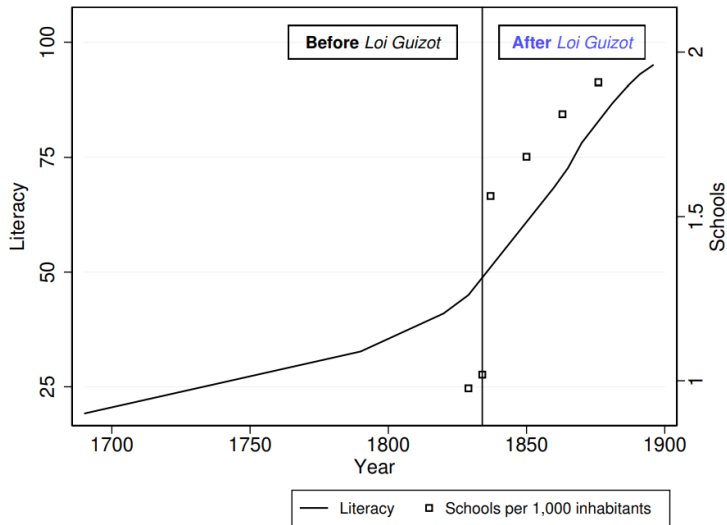


What the school was for

- Guizot (1833): “through the teaching of the French language, primary schools will instill and spread the spirit and unity of nationality everywhere”.
- A close advisor described each school as “a colony of French language in a conquered land” (Lorain, 1837).
- Before the law most teachers were clergy, or, in Weber’s list, “a retired soldier, a rural constable, the local barber, innkeeper, or grocer, or simply a half-educated peasant’s son”.
- The number of primary schools nearly doubled within a decade, and **universal literacy** followed.

Figure 4: Literacy and schools

Note: This figure displays the literacy rate (left) and number of primary schools per thousand inhabitants (right) over time in France. Source: Statistique Générale de la France ([n.d.a](#)).



The law was not applied everywhere

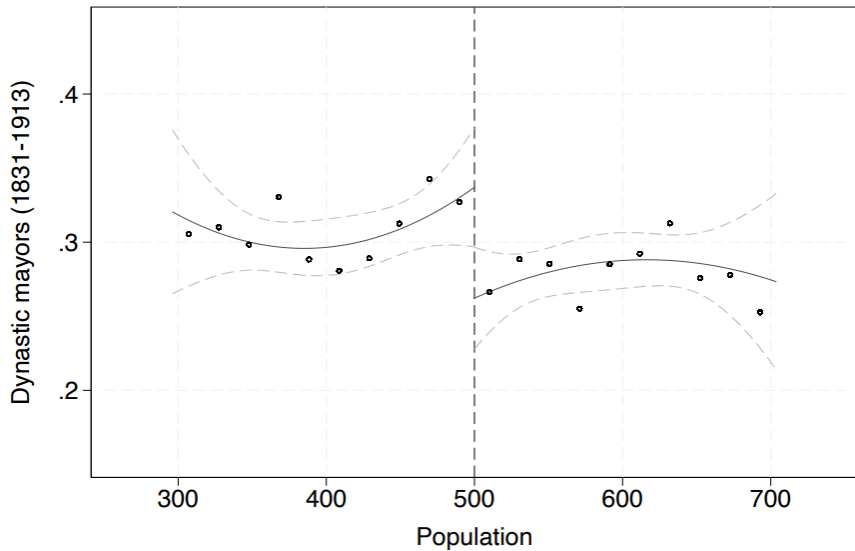
- Guizot to the National Assembly, 1834: “there are 21,000 municipalities in France that do not feel the need for primary instruction or that do not dare to do what it takes to satisfy this need”.
- Historians have long described the Guizot Law as applying above **500 inhabitants**, and departmental archives repeat the figure.
- But no such threshold appears in the text of the law or in any later decree.
- What did change at 500 was the Municipal Law: who was allowed to sit on the council.

The comparison

- Compare municipalities **just above** 500 inhabitants in the 1830s with those just below.
- Nothing else jumps at 500: altitude, ruggedness, distance to the coast, roads, market access, industrial establishments, Encyclopédie subscriptions, Napoleonic conscription, cadaster.
- No pile-up of villages just above the line, and no selective migration after the laws.
- Rural municipalities only, where 80.7 percent of the French population lived in 1836.

The council of families

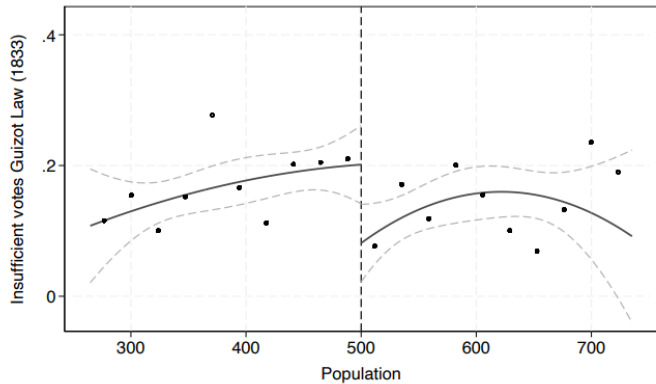
- Before 1831, small villages were run by a handful of related families. **Nepotism** and clientelism were the norm, especially after the Bourbon Restoration.
- The prefect of Aube, 1835: “The voters appoint themselves members of the municipal council; they are rarely able to read or write; they are all relatives or allies”.
- Landed elites had little use for schooling, a portable asset worth little to a landowner.
- Where they were removed, bourgeois notables came in, and they wanted schools.



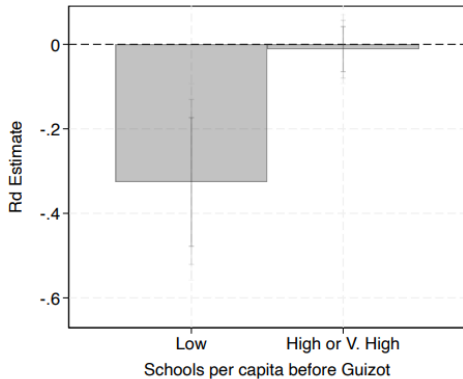
(Panel A) RD plot

The dynasties weakened

- Data: a crowdsourced genealogy site listing French mayors since the Revolution, about **248,000** names, cleaned and restricted to well documented municipalities.
- A mayor counts as dynastic if he shares a surname with a mayor from before 1831 in the same village.
- Above 500: about 10 percentage points less likely to have a dynastic mayor, against a base of about 30 percent below.
- Right after the Municipal Law the gap reaches nearly 20 percentage points, and it is driven entirely by the Bourbon families.



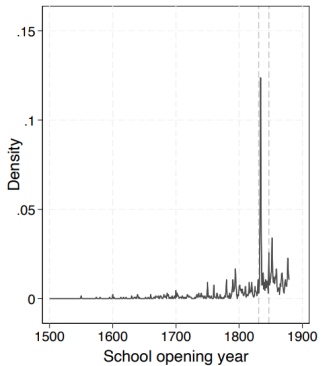
(Panel A) RD plot



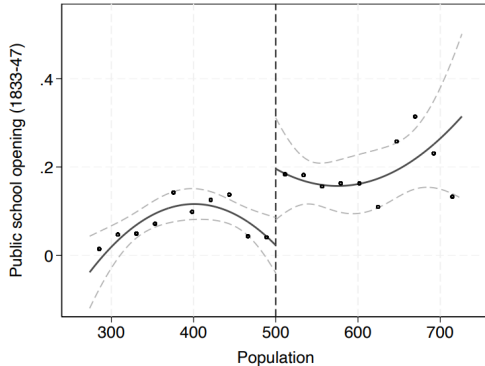
(Panel B) Heterogeneity: school density before

The vote of 1833

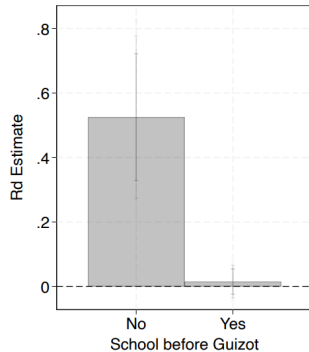
- After the Guizot Law passed, councils had to deliberate on funding it. Prefects tabulated who voted **insufficient** taxes, or refused any new tax at all.
- Archival work in seven departments, north and south, covering close to three thousand municipalities.
- Above 500, insufficient votes were roughly cut in half.
- The gap is largest where there were fewest schools before, that is, where a school had to be built from nothing.



(Panel A) Time series



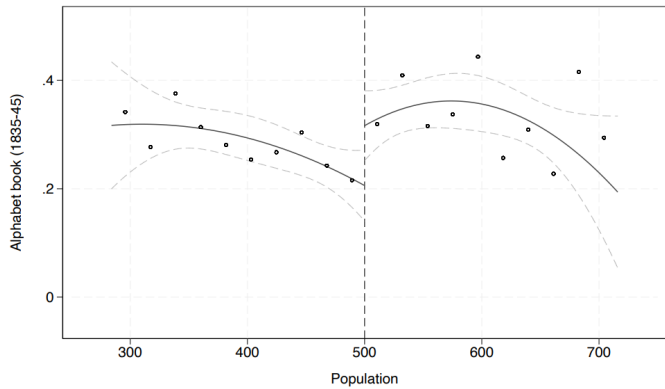
(Panel B) RD plot



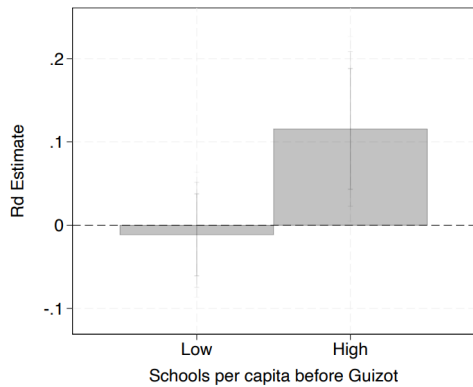
(Panel C) Heterogeneity: school before

Schools built

- Prefects in 1879 listed the opening date of every school in their jurisdiction. Openings jump right after 1833, by far the largest break in three centuries of records.
- Above 500, municipalities were much more likely to open a public school for boys or girls between 1833 and 1847.
- Among villages with **no school at all** before, the jump is about 60 percentage points.
- Secular schools and boys' schools, not religious ones: removing the landed elites also weakened the Church's hold on primary education.



(Panel A) RD plot



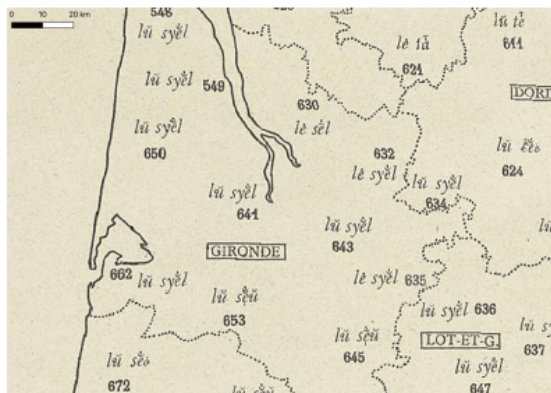
(Panel B) Heterogeneity: school density before

What was taught

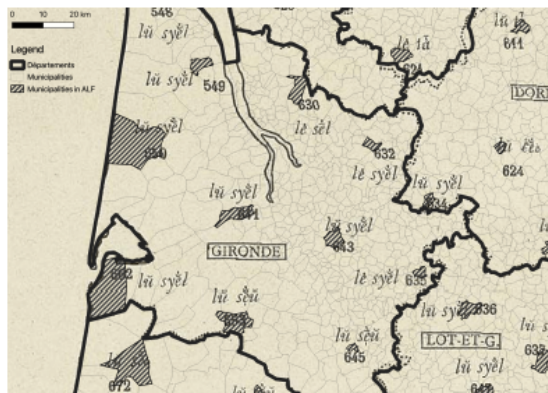
- The *Alphabet et premier livre de lecture*: the approved French reader, one million copies sent to schools within three years of the law.
- It taught standardized French together with lessons in conduct, obedience and morality, and put the other languages of France in second place.
- Above 500, schools were more likely to have it. No comparable jump for history books or the Bible, which took longer to write and distribute.
- Teachers: three normal schools in France in 1828, seventy-two by 1834, and a certificate exam built around written French and spelling.

Measuring the language of a village

- **Atlas Linguistique de la France**: from 1897 to 1901 Edmont traveled the country asking locals the common pronunciation of 1,920 words and expressions in 577 municipalities.
- One printed map per word (for example *ciel*, “sky”). Only spontaneous replies were recorded, and the aim was the average speech of the village, not of one person.
- Distance from French: compare the phonetic spelling of 50 everyday words (cat, dog, rain, water, sky, night) with the surveyed town closest to Paris.
- Timing is convenient: most adults in 1900 predate the Ferry Laws and the railway plan.



(Panel A) Map of *ciel* (“sky”)



(Panel B) With municipalities

Table 1: Digitized maps (words) from the Swadesh list in the *Atlas*

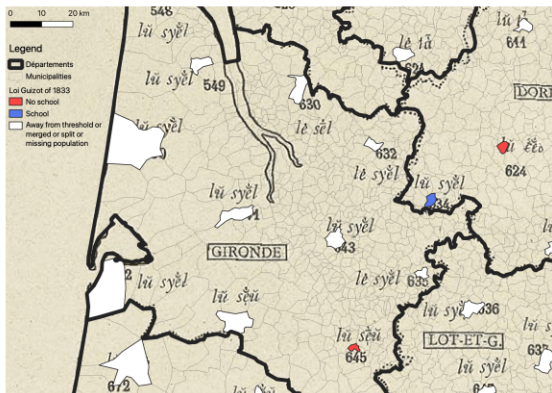
Note: This table displays the words (or maps) that we have digitized from the *Atlas Linguistique de la France*. We also report the corresponding map number in the *Atlas* for each word.

Maps of the *Atlas Linguistique de la France*

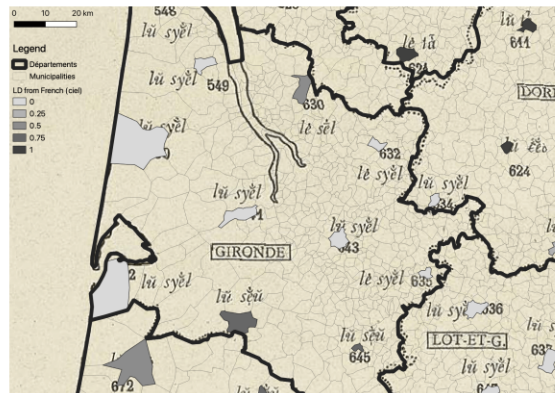
43	animal	142	drink	796	hand	923	new	1241	sun
210	ashes	946	ear	314	how	929	night	894	swim
1	bee	1299	earth	638	knee	908	nose	1120	tail
916	black	558	fire	1200	know	76	others	233	to sing
1187	blood	1052	fish	559	leaf	1039	rain	344	to spit
250	cat	582	flowers	120	lots	1159	river	750	tongue
461	child	178	fog	788	moon	285	sky	52	trees
612	cold	615	fruit	874	mountain	418	sleep	397	two
882	die	1031	full	151	mouth	494	star	432	water
279	dog	270	hair	328	neck	1014	stone	594	wood

One corner of Gironde

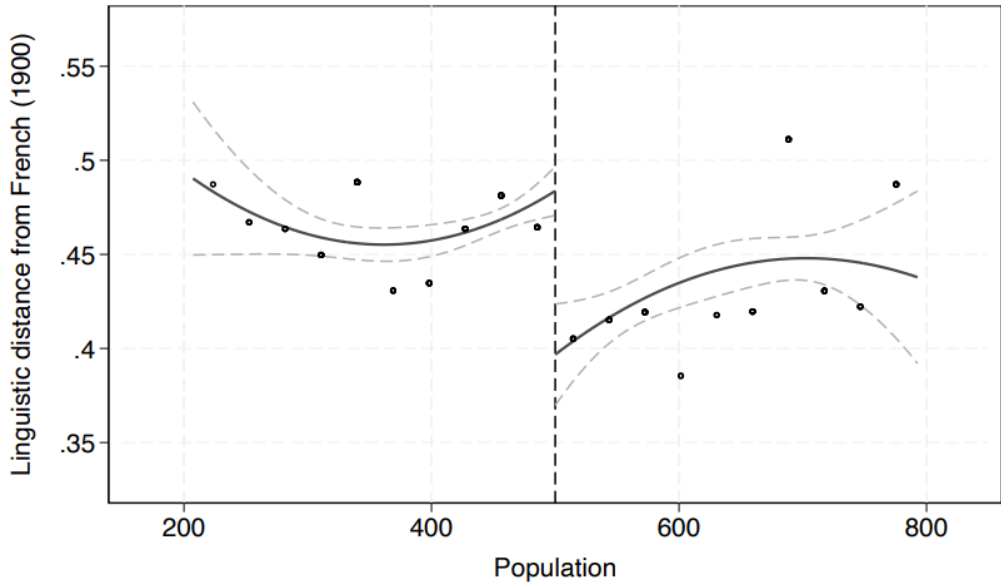
- Same map, twice: which villages were above the threshold when the Guizot Law came in, and how far each one's speech sat from French.
- Neighboring villages a few miles apart said *ciel*, *cel* or *ceu*.
- Moving from *ceu* to *ciel* changes both the **word** and the vowel.



(Panel D) With treatment status after *Loi Guizot* (state-sponsored education)

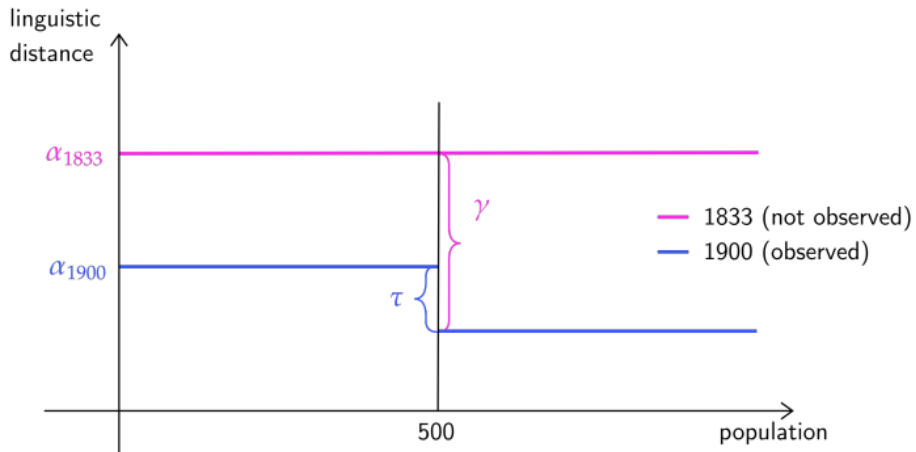


(Panel E) Linguistic distance from French (*ciel*)



Schooling moved everyday speech toward French

- Distance from French in 1900 falls by about **0.10** at the threshold, on a scale running from zero to one.
- That is roughly 20 percent of what the distance would otherwise have been, and more than a third of the median gap between the Occitan and the oil regions.
- The Atlas recorded the speech of the village, not the speech of the classroom. So this is French adopted in daily life.
- Villages near the threshold are underrepresented in the south, where distance was greatest, so the estimate is if anything too small.



$$|g| \equiv |\gamma| / \alpha_{1833}$$

$$0 \leq |\tau| / \alpha_{1900} \leq |g|$$

How fast did it happen

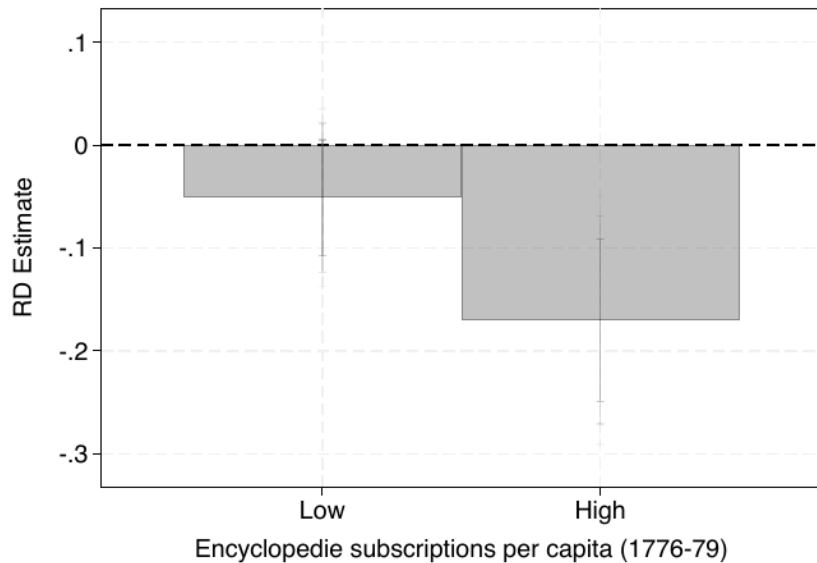
- Only one snapshot of language exists, 1900. Nobody surveyed village speech in 1833.
- If schooling pushed in the same direction as the overall drift of the century, the gap visible in 1900 is a **floor** on how fast homogenization ran.
- Reading: distance from French fell by at least 20 percent between 1833 and 1900 at the threshold.

Whose French

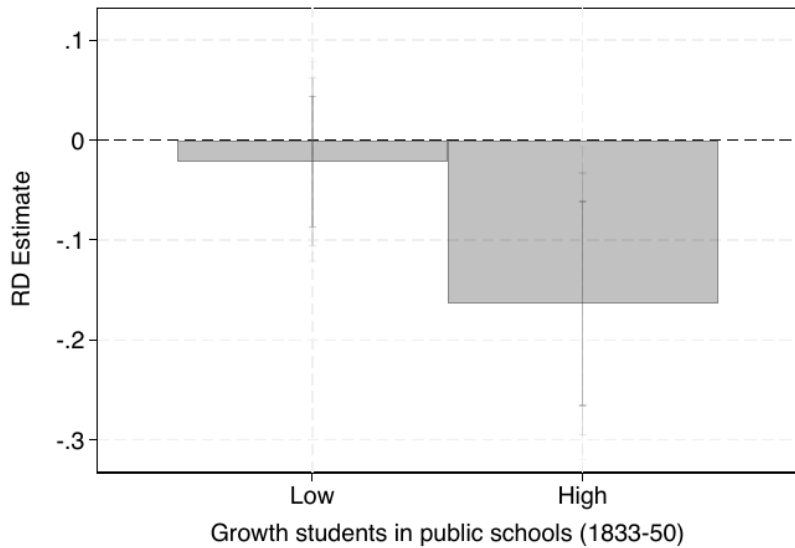
- Redo the comparison using each surveyed town in turn as the reference point for “French”.
- Villages above the threshold moved toward the speech of the **Paris Basin and the Loire Valley**, above all Touraine and Anjou. Not toward peripheral languages.
- Paris supplied the Francien dialect; the Loire hosted the royal court in the Renaissance; Anjou was the seat of the Angevin dynasty.
- The school spread the language of the elites, and this doubles as a check on the design.

Vocabulary in the south, accent in the north

- In the historically Occitan south, villages above the threshold used **30 percentage points** more French words. In the north, no change in vocabulary.
- In the north what moves instead is pronunciation: a gradual drift of dialects toward the common language.
- Distance falls by about 8 percent in the oil region and about 30 percent in the Occitan region.
- The south is where the identity cost of switching was highest, and it switched most.



(Panel A) Knowledge elites



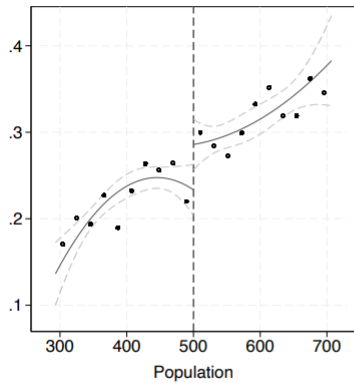
(Panel C) Educational demand

Where the policy worked

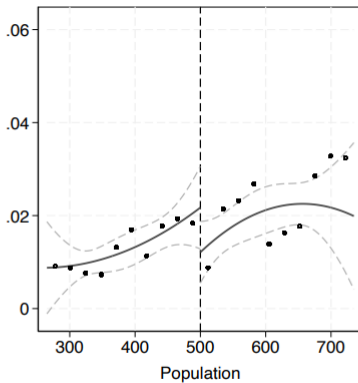
- Larger where **knowledge elites** were present, proxied by subscriptions to the Encyclopédie before the Revolution.
- Larger where the number of students in public schools grew fastest after 1833, and where railways later expanded.
- The same across levels of income per capita, so this is not simply the richer places.
- Guizot did not make attendance compulsory. Families had to want the school, and schooling also supplied reading, writing and arithmetic.

What would have broken the story

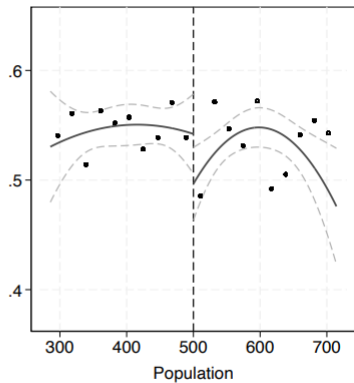
- Move the cutoff anywhere between 300 and 700 inhabitants: no jump.
- Measure population in other years of the century: no jump, except around 1831 and 1836.
- Across more than 400 such false tests, fewer than 9 percent produce a detectable break, against over 96 percent at 500 inhabitants in 1831 or 1836.
- No jump at 500 in cadasters, post offices, roads or railways. The change in council composition moved **schooling**, not public goods in general.



(Panel A) Resistance heroes (WWII)



(Panel B) Nazi collaborators (WWII)



(Panel C) Regionalization (1969)

The long run

- Above the threshold, villages were more likely to be the birthplace of someone awarded the Médaille de la Résistance for “remarkable acts of faith and courage that contributed to the resistance of the French people against the enemy”.
- Less likely to be the birthplace of men who joined the Gestapo, the German Intelligence Service or the Waffen-SS.
- In the 1969 referendum, support for handing power back to the regions was about 5 percentage points lower. Nationally the referendum was rejected by 52.4 percent.
- The **Resistance** result is the firm one; collaboration and the referendum are suggestive, since collaborators are rare.

Takeaway

- France **assimilated**. The paper documents successful nation building, not backlash.
- Coercion alone did not do it. Local power had to shift first, and families had to want what the school offered.
- Nation building took hold as the returns to human capital rose, in the transition out of stagnation.
- Question for the next paper: what happens when the state bans a language instead of supplying a new one?

Backlash: German banned in US schools

Fouka (2020)

Backlash: The Unintended Effects of Language Prohibition in U.S. Schools after World War I

Vasiliki Fouka ✉

The Review of Economic Studies, Volume 87, Issue 1, January 2020, Pages 204–239,

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Abstract

Do forced assimilation policies always succeed in integrating immigrant groups? This article examines how a specific assimilation policy—language restrictions in elementary school—affects integration and identification with the host country later in life. After World War I, several U.S. states barred the German language from their schools. Affected individuals were less likely to volunteer in World War II and more likely to marry within their ethnic group and to choose decidedly German names for their offspring. Rather than facilitating the assimilation of immigrant children, the policy instigated a backlash, heightening the sense of cultural identity among the minority.

Germans in the United States

- The single largest foreign group to migrate to the post-colonial US. In 1900 the first and second generation together were more than 10 percent of the population.
- A large network of private, mainly religious, schools teaching in German, and half-day German-English programs in the public schools of Cincinnati and Indianapolis.
- Minnesota, 1917: 308 parochial schools with 38,853 pupils, more than two thirds of them teaching in both German and English.
- Higham: “public opinion had come to accept the Germans as one of the most assimilable and reputable of immigrant groups”.

2.2. *WWI, anti-Germanism, and language restrictions*

The outbreak of the First World War made the large German community the focus of American patriotic reaction. The growing anti-Germanism of the early war years, which was further agitated by the insistence of the German-American press on strict American neutrality, found its expression in a series of both spontaneous and organized acts of harassment and persecution once the U.S. entered the war in 1917. Numerous German-Americans were arrested as spies or forced to demonstrate their loyalty by buying liberty bonds under the threat of vandalism or tarring and feathering. The hanging of Robert Prager in Collinsville, Illinois, was the most well known in a series of lynching attacks against German-Americans (Luebke, 1974). Berlin, Michigan, was renamed to Marne in honour of the American soldiers who fought in the Second Battle of Marne. Hamburgers became “liberty steaks”⁵ and sauerkraut consumption fell by 75% in the period 1914–1918 (*New York Times*, 25 April 1918). Moser (2012) shows that the number of German-language operas staged at the New York Metropolitan Opera fell dramatically during the war years.

1917 and after

- US entry into the war turned the community into a target: arrests as spies, forced purchases of liberty bonds, the **lynching** of Robert Prager in Collinsville.
- Berlin, Michigan was renamed Marne. Hamburgers became liberty steaks. Sauerkraut consumption fell 75 percent between 1914 and 1918.
- The governor of Iowa: “English should and must be the only medium of instruction in public, private, denominational, and other similar schools”.
- Between 1917 and 1923, 23 states restricted foreign languages in elementary grades.

3.1. *Laws*

Both Indiana and Ohio explicitly singled out German as a language to be prohibited in elementary school grades in 1919.⁷ The law in Ohio reads as follows:

That all subjects and branches taught in the elementary schools of the state of Ohio below the eighth grade shall be taught in the English language only...Provided, that the German language shall not be taught below the eighth grade in any of the elementary schools of this state. (108 Ohio Laws, 614, 1919)

The wording was almost identical in Indiana:

All private and parochial schools...shall be taught in the English language only...provided, that the German language shall not be taught in any such schools within this state. (School Laws of Indiana, 1919)

The law

- **Indiana and Ohio**, 1919: the only two states to name German. Ohio: “the German language shall not be taught below the eighth grade in any of the elementary schools of this state”.
- What made these laws bite is that they reached private and parochial schools, where German actually was the medium of instruction.
- The Supreme Court struck them down in 1923. German teaching never returned to its earlier level.

The question

- Does banning a language **assimilate** a minority, or harden it?
- Nation-building models assume that imposing a national language raises homogeneity.
- Models of cultural transmission allow the opposite: parents invest more in identity precisely when the outside world attacks it.
- Fouka provides the first empirical test of that possibility.

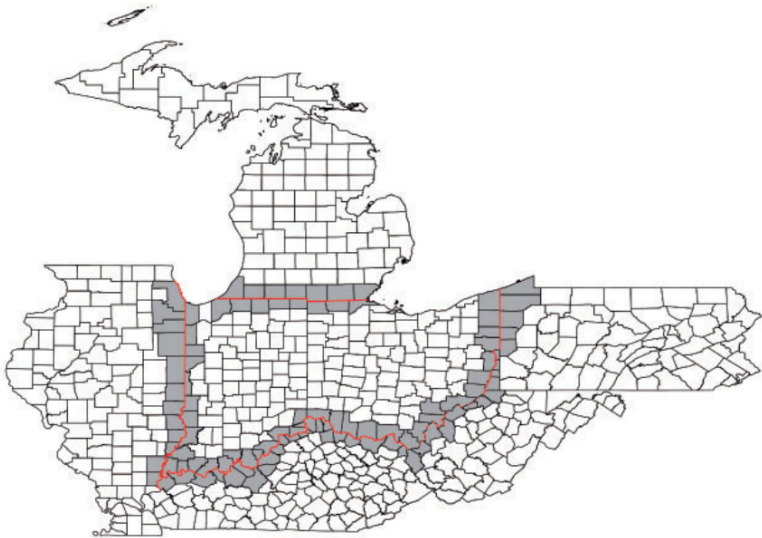


FIGURE 1
Counties on the borders of Indiana and Ohio

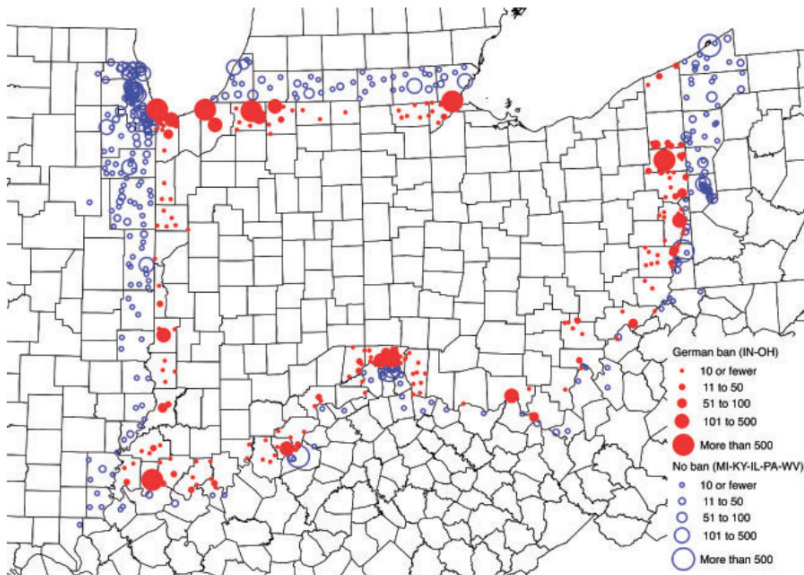


FIGURE 2

Locations of linked data set in 1920

The comparison

- Cohorts young enough to be in school in 1919, by their state's compulsory schooling ages, against older cohorts.
- In Indiana and Ohio against their neighbors: Illinois, Michigan, Kentucky, West Virginia, Pennsylvania.
- Only counties **on the border**, so the Germans being compared live a few miles apart. Population density, urbanization, share German-born and share Lutheran are balanced across the line.
- The timing came from the war, not from anything specific to German communities in these two states.

The data and three signals of identity

- The full 1920 census: all US-born men born 1880 to 1916 with German parents living in a border county, linked forward to 1930 and 1940.
- **The name given to a child**, scored by how much more common it is among Germans: Hans, Karl, Otto, August, Adolph at the top; Clyde, Russell, Melvin at the bottom.
- **Marrying inside the group.**
- **Volunteering** for the US Army in the Second World War: a choice of side between host country and country of origin, read off enlistment serial numbers.

B.2 German Name Index

The German Name Index follows Fryer and Levitt (2004) and is constructed as follows

$$\text{GNI}_{\text{name},c} = \frac{\text{Pr}(\text{name}|\text{German}_c)}{\text{Pr}(\text{name}|\text{German}_c) + \text{Pr}(\text{name}|\text{non-German}_c)} \times 100$$

where c indexes birth cohorts. To compute this index, I use information from the 1930 5% IPUMS sample (Ruggles et al., 2010) and define $\text{Pr}(\text{German})$ as the share of foreign-born individuals in the census that were born in Germany. The non-German

TABLE 3
Most and least German-sounding names in the 1930 census

Highest-scoring				Lowest-scoring			
Name	Total	Germans	GNI	Name	Total	Germans	GNI
Hans	1281	325	98.91	Clyde	7359	0	0
Karl	1542	267	96.21	Russell	6049	0	0
Otto	5693	962	94.78	Melvin	5687	0	0
August	5781	1264	92.30	Patrick	5381	0	0
Christian	1215	179	90.99	Leroy	5187	0	0
Adolph	3231	385	90.27	Warren	5077	0	0
Gustave	1271	231	90.21	Marvin	4588	0	0
Emil	4261	515	89.52	Jim	4231	0	0
Rudolph	3372	296	89.06	Glenn	3898	0	0
Herman	11446	1399	88.27	Leslie	3796	0	0

Notes: The table shows the values of the German name index for the 10 highest-scoring (left panel) and 10 lowest-scoring (right panel) names of males born in 1910 in the 1930 5% IPUMS sample. Highest-scoring names are chosen among names that appear at least 1,000 times in the 1930 sample and are ordered by their GNI value; lowest-scoring names are ordered by popularity. See Section 3.2 and Section B.2 of the [Supplementary Appendix](#) for details on the construction of the GNI.

TABLE 2
Summary statistics: border data set

	Found in 1930			Found in 1940		
	Mean	S.D.	N	Mean	S.D.	N
Married	0.695	0.460	35,886	0.790	0.407	41,875
Spouse of German ancestry	0.395	0.489	24,925	—	—	—
Number of children	2.398	1.543	20,008	2.206	1.450	25,393
Log average GNI of children	1.774	3.153	19,684	1.305	3.497	20,098
Log GNI of first son	1.358	3.662	14,309	1.095	3.775	12,816
Years of education	—	—	—	8.546	2.595	25,103
Log yearly salary earnings	—	—	—	6.920	2.144	19,305

Notes: The table shows summary statistics for males born 1880–1916 to German parents, who in 1920 lived in a county on either side of the border of Indiana and Ohio with Illinois, Michigan, Kentucky, West Virginia, or Pennsylvania and who were linked to the census of 1930 (left panel) or 1940 (right panel). See Section 3.2 and Section B.2 of the [Supplementary Appendix](#) for details on the construction of the GNI variables.

TABLE 4
Summary statistics: WWII enlistments

	All			German parents		
	Mean	S.D.	N	Mean	S.D.	N
Age	19.629	4.863	160,780	22.358	5.768	2,679
Married	0.011	0.107	160,780	0.014	0.120	2,679
With dependents	0.107	0.309	160,780	0.155	0.362	2,679
Volunteer	0.109	0.312	160,780	0.079	0.270	2,679
High school graduate	0.374	0.484	160,780	0.274	0.446	2,679
College graduate	0.064	0.244	160,780	0.045	0.207	2,679

Notes: The table reports summary statistics for males who enlisted in the U.S. Army between 1940 and 1942 and were linked to the 1930 census. The data comprise cohorts born 1880–1916 in Indiana, Ohio, Illinois, Michigan, Kentucky, West Virginia, and Pennsylvania to German parents. The right panel restricts the sample to individuals with German parents. Volunteers are identified as having a serial number in the 11 through 19 million series.

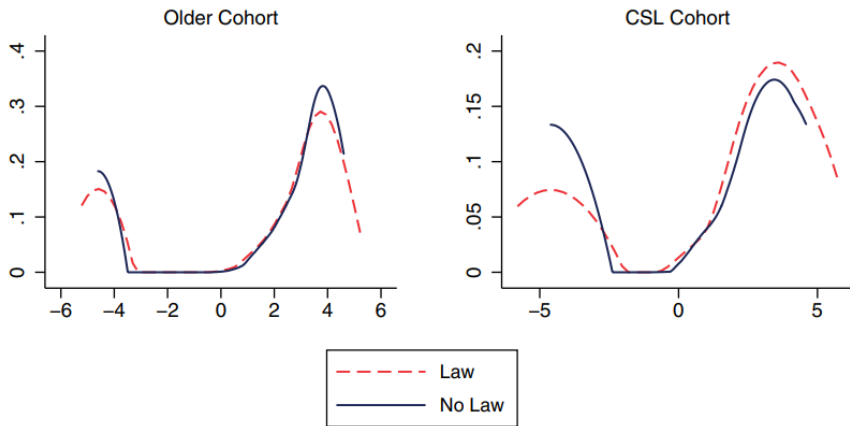


FIGURE 3

Densities of log GNI of first son by cohort

Notes: The figure illustrates, for the linked border data set, the kernel density of the logarithm of the GINI of the first son. The panel on the left plots this density for the cohort too old to have been in school (by compulsory law) at the time German was banned; the right panel plots the density for the treated cohort.

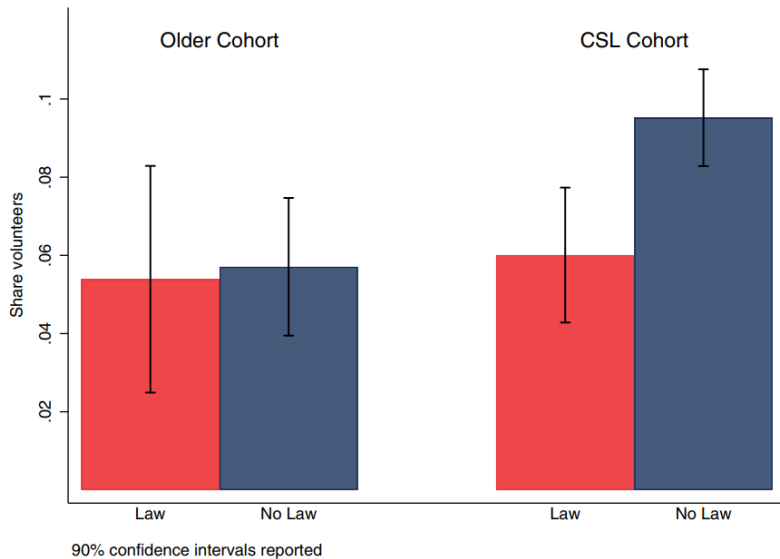


FIGURE 4
Share of volunteers by cohort and law status

Backlash

- Exposed cohorts married within the group 3.6 to 5.7 percentage points more often.
- They volunteered 2.6 percentage points less, against an average volunteering rate of 11 percent among the younger cohorts.
- They gave their children more German names: on the order of moving from a name like David or Daniel to a name like **Adolph**.
- The gap in volunteering is near zero for cohorts too old to have been in school when the ban came in.

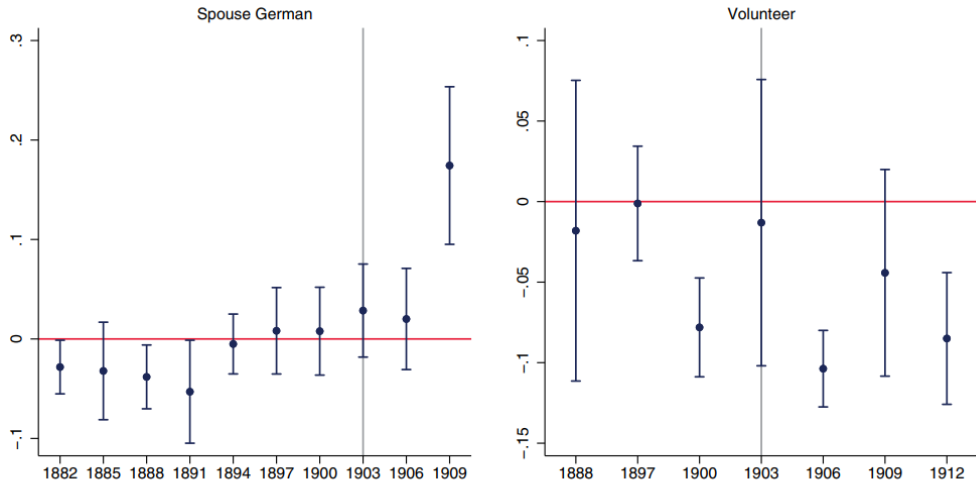
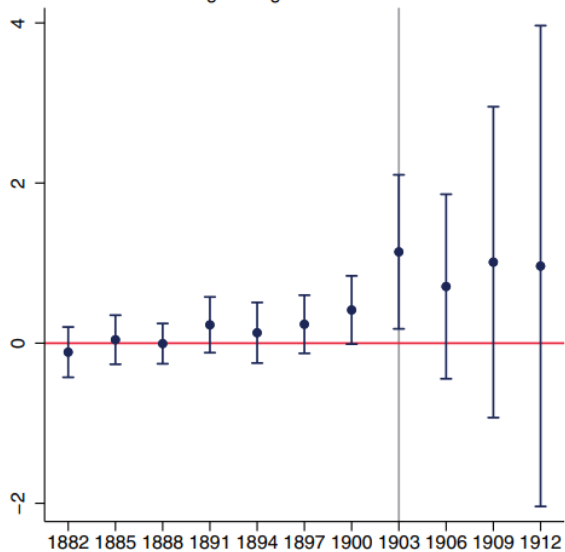


FIGURE 5

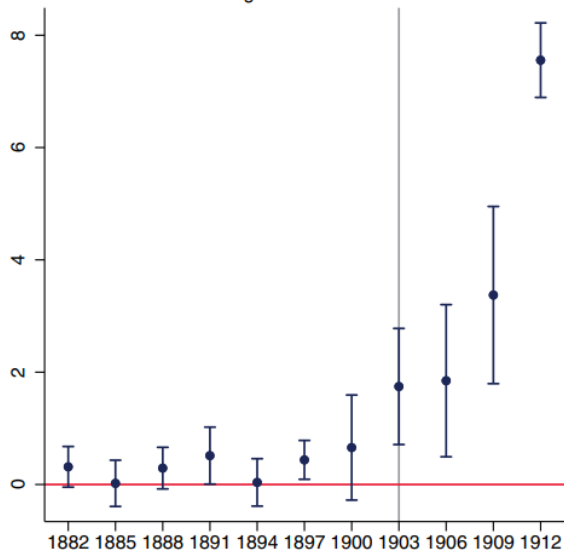
Estimated effects of language ban by birth cohort bin

Notes: The figure shows coefficient estimates and 95% confidence intervals from a regression of each outcome on state and birth cohort fixed effects and a set of interactions of 3-year birth cohort bins with an indicator for a language ban. The vertical line in year 1903 indicates the first cohort to be affected by the language ban.

Log average GNI of children

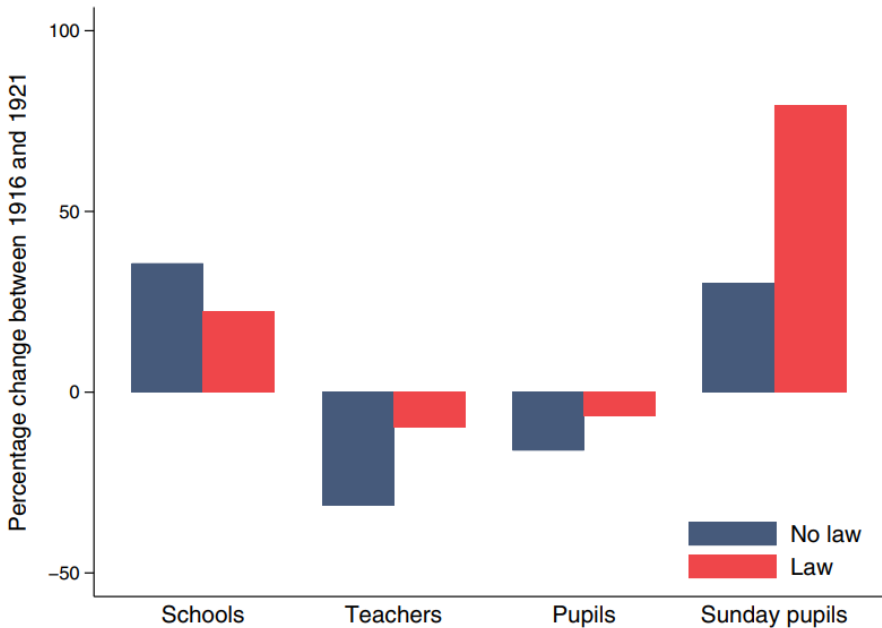


Log GNI of first son



Whose children reacted

- The effect weakens, or reverses, for children of **mixed** couples. What carries the reaction is the parents' own identity.
- It is stronger where Germans were a smaller share of the county: parents work harder when peers will not do the socializing.
- It is stronger where Lutherans were many, the church that pushed parochial schooling in German.



Parents, not the church

- Lutheran Church, Missouri Synod: after the war, Sunday-school enrollment rose in the states that had banned German.
- The number of schools, of teachers, and of services held in German did not.
- So the backlash came from **parental demand** for German enculturation, not from a supply push by the church.

What it cost

- Schooling did not fall. If anything, years of education rose for the exposed cohorts.
- So the reaction did not come through worse education.
- There is weak evidence of **lower earnings** for those who became more German: a private price for not assimilating.

Two verdicts on the same instrument

- Blanc and Kubo: assimilation. Fouka: **backlash**. Both through the elementary school.
- France supplied a new language that was becoming valuable, and never forced attendance.
- Indiana and Ohio prohibited a language, in wartime, aiming squarely at the minority's own schools.
- Blanc and Kubo read their result against a list of backlash findings, Fouka's among them, and ask why France is the exception.

Backlash: the headscarf ban in France

The same question, today

- Abdelgadir and Fouka: France barred conspicuous religious symbols from public schools, the **headscarf** among them.
- Muslim girls exposed to the ban completed secondary school less often, with knock-on effects on work and on family formation.
- Reported experience of racism at school rises, trust in French school falls.
- Both identities strengthen: they feel more French, and more attached to the father's country of origin.

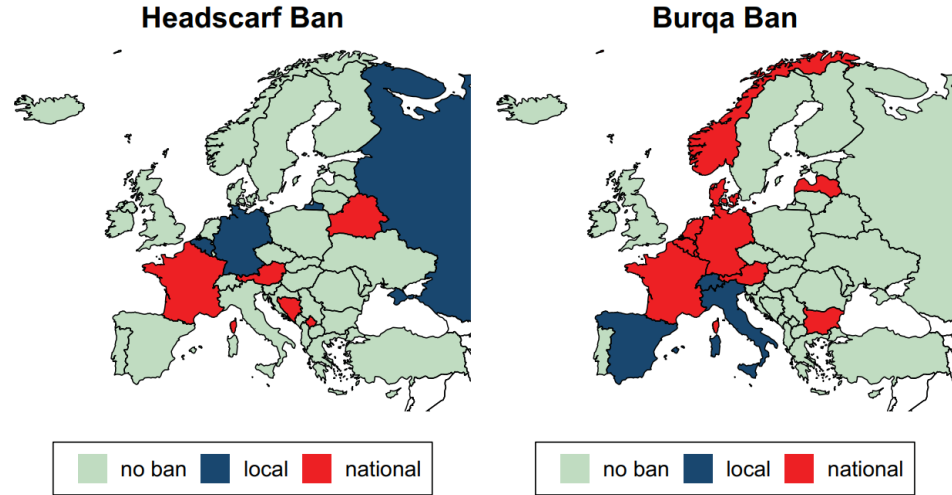
Political Secularism and Muslim Integration in the West: Assessing the Effects of the French Headscarf Ban

AALA ABDELGADIR *Stanford University*

VASILIKI FOUKA *Stanford University*

In response to rising immigration flows and the fear of Islamic radicalization, several Western countries have enacted policies to restrict religious expression and emphasize secularism and Western values. Despite intense public debate, there is little systematic evidence on how such policies influence the behavior of the religious minorities they target. In this paper, we use rich quantitative and qualitative data to evaluate the effects of the 2004 French headscarf ban on the socioeconomic integration of French Muslim women. We find that the law reduces the secondary educational attainment of Muslim girls and affects their trajectory in the labor market and family composition in the long run. We provide evidence that the ban operates through increased perceptions of discrimination and that it strengthens both national and religious identities.

FIGURE 1. Prevalence of Laws Regulating Veiling across Europe



Note: The figures describe the status of veiling laws. The left panel illustrates the prevalence of headscarf laws. The right panel maps the prevalence of full-face veil (burqa or niqab) laws. Laws include bans implemented in all public spaces or specific contexts such as schools or courts. “Local” and “national” refer to the level of government that implements the law. Data is from the European Commission (2017) and Open Society Foundations (2018).

Rates of Secondary Education Completion by Birth Cohort for French-Born Women

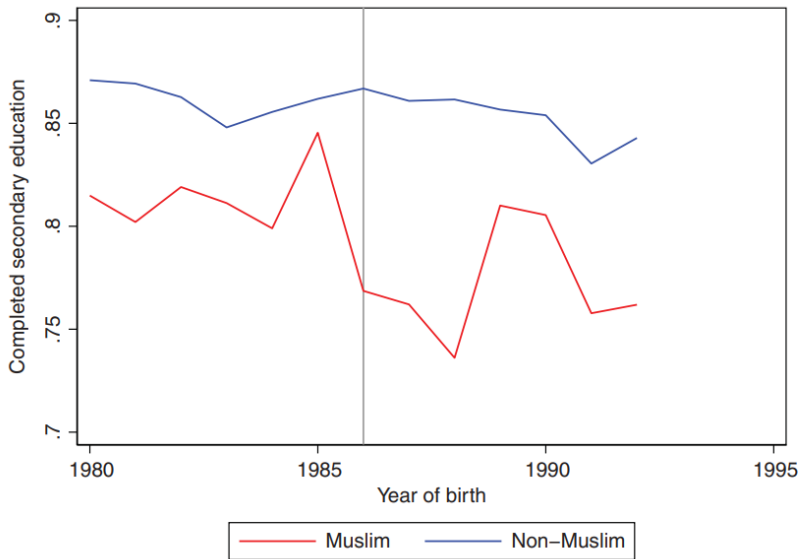
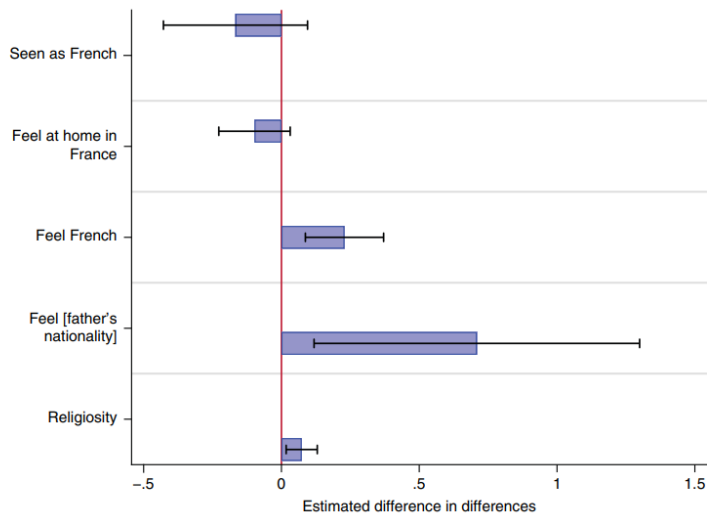
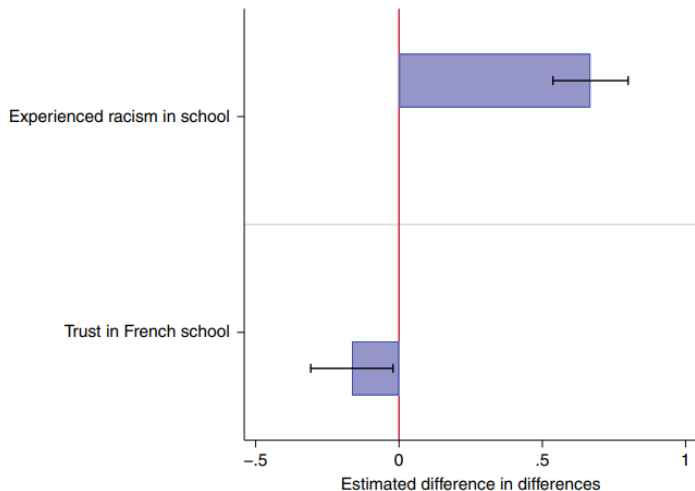


FIGURE 3. Effects on Self-Reported Measures of Identity



Note: The figure plots coefficient estimates and 90% confidence intervals from the interaction between Muslim religion and an indicator for individuals born after 1985. The regression controls for birth cohort and religion fixed effects, as well as for a linear Muslim-specific age trend. The sample consists of French-born women born 1980 or later. For all outcomes but religiosity the sample is restricted to women with foreign-born parents. Outcomes are standardized and estimated effects can be interpreted in terms of standard deviations.

FIGURE 4. Experiences in and Views of French School.



Note: The figure plots coefficient estimates and 90% confidence intervals from the interaction between Muslim religion and an indicator for individuals born after 1985. The regression controls for birth cohort and religion fixed effects, as well as for a linear Muslim-specific age trend. The sample consists of French-born women born 1980 or later. Outcomes are standardized and estimated effects can be interpreted in terms of standard deviations.

In this class

- Nations are recent and were **built**, largely through the school.
- France: state-sponsored education moved everyday speech toward French, where local power had shifted and families wanted schooling.
- The United States: banning a minority language hardened the minority instead of dissolving it.
- Same instrument, opposite results. What differs is who supplies the schooling, and whether the target has a choice.